

The Fate of South Vietnam

For those living in the former South Vietnam, life under the new communist regime could be difficult. Many people were persecuted due to their politics, religion, or even career choice, causing large numbers of South Vietnamese to flee their homeland for good.

◀ BEFORE

The government in Saigon did not last long after the departure of US forces in 1973.

FALL OF SAIGON

In Spring 1975, a North Vietnamese **offensive** swept through South Vietnam and the ARVN collapsed. President Thieu fled the country. After the ARVN were defeated at Xuan Loc, the NVA marched uncontested toward Saigon. A last-minute **evacuation** of US personnel and some South Vietnamese from the rooftop of the US Embassy ensued as the communist forces **entered the city**.



SEIZED PRESIDENTIAL PALACE IN SAIGON

In the frantic evacuation of the US Embassy, officials left behind many undestroyed files. Among these was a list of 30,000 Vietnamese who had worked in the Phoenix Program, helping to root out Viet Cong agents in rural areas. These individuals were quickly rounded up—later reports suggest that they were executed.

Although the feared bloodbath on a larger scale did not occur immediately, South Vietnamese citizens suffered deeply at the hands of the new regime. The North Vietnamese swept aside the People's Revolutionary Government (the political organ of the earlier Viet Cong) and in 1976 unified North and South as the Socialist Republic of Vietnam (SRV).

Sent away

As many as 2.5 million South Vietnamese—former military officers, civil servants, capitalists, priests, teachers, intellectuals, and others identified with the former regime—were dispatched to more than 300 “re-education” or “thought reform” camps in the countryside. Survivors, some of whom spent as many as 10 years incarcerated, described hard and dangerous work (including mine sweeping), a glaring shortage of food and